

Constitutional Language Protocol (CLP)

Version 0.1

Clause 0 — Foundational Layer Declaration (Non-Removable)

The Constitutional Language Protocol (CLP) is a descriptive semantic protocol.

CLP exists solely to make authority, constraints, and failure conditions explicit and legible within complex systems.

CLP does not prescribe outcomes.

CLP does not enforce behavior.

CLP does not assert legitimacy.

CLP does not function as an alignment mechanism.

This clause is non-removable.

1. Scope

CLP applies to any system in which authority is exercised, constraints are present, and failure is possible.

This includes, but is not limited to:

- Organizational systems
- Technical systems
- Socio-technical systems
- AI and non-AI systems
- Hybrid human-machine systems

2. Descriptive Posture

All CLP statements are descriptive.

A CLP statement:

- May describe what is claimed
- May describe what is exercised
- May describe what is constrained
- May describe how failure manifests

A CLP statement:

- Does not judge correctness
- Does not recommend action
- Does not imply endorsement

3. Core Dimensions

A minimal CLP description consists of three dimensions.

3.1 Authority

Authority describes who is claimed to decide, who actually decides, and who is accountable for consequences.

Authority may be:

- Declared
- Exercised
- Delegated
- Contested
- Implicit

No assumption of legitimacy is made.

3.2 Constraints

Constraints describe limiting factors that shape system behavior.

Constraints may include:

- Resource limits
- Time limits
- Legal or contractual limits
- Physical or technical limits
- Social or institutional limits

Constraints may be explicit or implicit.

3.3 Failure Visibility

Failure visibility describes how system failure manifests.

Failure may be:

- Immediate or delayed
- Visible or silent
- Localized or systemic
- Recoverable or irreversible

CLP does not define acceptable failure.

4. CLP Blocks

A CLP block is a structured, human-readable description using the core dimensions.

Example:

Authority:

Declared: Steering Committee
Exercised: Automated Process
Accountable: Funding Body

Constraints:

Budget: Fixed
Time: Variable
Maintenance: Deferred

Failure Visibility:

Silent failure possible when automation overrides maintenance

5. Non-Normativity

CLP is intentionally non-normative.

CLP does not define:

- Best practices
- Compliance requirements
- Ethical standards
- Correct system design

Any normative interpretation is external to CLP.

6. Adoption and Extension

CLP may be:

- Used partially or fully
- Embedded within other documents
- Extended with additional descriptive fields
- Ignored entirely

Extensions must not alter or remove Clause 0.

7. Rejection

Rejection of CLP is a valid outcome.

CLP does not seek universal adoption.